

with purity and being non-judgemental. It's only later we learn to discriminate."

Sitaare Zameen Par arrives at a time when the yardstick of what works at the box office has undergone a seismic shift. Loud spectacles with hypermasculine heroes are favoured over slice-of-life soft outings. Khan's last film, *Laal Singh Chaddha*, a remake of the Hollywood hit *Forrest Gump*, crashed at the box office. *Sitaare Zameen Par*, which has been pegged as a "spiritual sequel" to Khan's own directorial debut, *Taare Zameen Par*, is inspired by a Spanish film, *Campeones* (2018). Prasanna isn't too worried that the film may seem an anomaly in the current landscape. "Everyone wants a palate-cleanser. A film works if it entertains and has a strong emotional connect with people," he says. "Everything changes with one thing. It's Aamir Khan who usually starts the trend." ■

—Suhani Singh

OTT ▼

What Lies Beneath

Ostensibly a survival drama, KARAN TEJPAL's *Stolen* touches upon a number of societal concerns

The journey from apathy to empathy is a fraught one in Karan Tejpal's debut film, *Stolen*, which is currently streaming on Amazon Prime Video. Inspired by the horrific events in Karbi Anglong in Assam, in which two young men mistaken for being child kidnappers were lynched by a mob, Tejpal crafts a survival drama that pushes the anxiety buttons and touches on many pertinent issues afflicting society today.



QUIET DREAD Mia Maelzer plays a mother looking for her abducted toddler

From the dangers of fake news shared on WhatsApp groups to public distrust of police and privileged middle-class India's wariness towards those on the economic fringes, *Stolen* pushes audiences on the edge and challenges them with a stark depiction of reality. "The Karbi Anglong videos were always on my mind and left a knot in my stomach," says Tejpal. "I wanted the audience to feel the anxiety and present a sanitised version of the reality." In the process, he also poses a pivotal question: Would you take a stand?

Starring Abhishek Banerjee, Shubham Vardhan and Mia Maelzer in a pitch-perfect act as a mother looking for her abducted toddler, *Stolen* rarely misses a beat. At the crux of it, the film deals with the dilemmas around doing the right thing. For Banerjee, it's the relatability of the situation that made Tejpal's script irresistible. Initially approached to play Raman, the morally upright brother who goes out of his way to help a distraught mother, Banerjee was eventually asked to play Gautam, the sibling who is all too aware of the mess the brothers are getting themselves into. "There's a tendency to not be in trouble," says Banerjee of the character. "What he dreads is happening. It's only when everything is lost and there is no other option but to rise."

The emotional spine of *Stolen* though is Maelzer. Tejpal is all praise for the National School of Drama alumna in what's a breakthrough role. "Mia suggested we plant her in a Santhal area. She knew the language and was aware of the people and issues. The specificity she brought to the role was great," says Tejpal, who, too, makes a solid first impression with *Stolen*. ■

—Suhani Singh